

IRRFAN, 47

“They cut my role by half, otherwise I would have got an Oscar nomination.”

If they hadn't cut my role, I am sure I would have been nominated,” says Irrfan. In the parts that were edited, Irrfan is shown first being told by Prem Kumar (Anil Kapoor) and the IG Police (played by Vijay Kashyap who now doesn't feature in the film) that he has to extract a confession from the kid. He then realises Jamal (Dev Patel) is speaking the truth, and escorts him back to the show. “It was a pivotal role but it would have made Jamal seem less heroic,” says Irrfan. He's never been one to fight destiny. And why not? His role in *Salaam Bombay* was completely cut out of the movie because of height issues. Yet Mira Nair cast him again, to great critical acclaim, in *The Namesake*. “In fact, whenever I have auditioned for a role I have never got it, whether it was an agent in *MI-3* or the Moroccan in *Body of Lies*.” But now, as India's most celebrated international star,

roles, big and small, are written for him. “Michael Winterbottom, who directed *A Mighty Heart*, came to me, so did Mira. Wes Anderson liked my work in *The Namesake* so much that he wrote two lines for me in *Darjeeling Limited*,” says Irrfan. He's had the same American agent ever since Asif Kapadia's *The Warrior* made it big. He's just wrapped a segment directed by Nair, playing a Jain diamond merchant, in *New York, I Love You*; done a part in *Hiss*, Jennifer Lynch's remake of the Nagina myth; and acted as a Muslim FBI officer in Kabir Khan's *New York*. And oh yes, Angelina Jolie has promised him a comedy as well. For now, he's wearing his own Ralph Lauren tuxedo to the Oscars. With appearances at the Cannes red carpet with Jolie and in New York with Nair, it's an investment he has had to make.

BHASKAR PAUL



A.R. RAHMAN, 41

“Whenever there is great trauma, there's good work. That's what happened on *Slumdog*.”

He's the biggest phenomenon, but also the quietest. While the ensemble cast has been whopping it up, Rahman has been tying up his commitments in India. When he returned from winning the Golden Globe for the best music score, he wrapped up the long-pending background score for Rakeysh Omprakash Mehra's *Delhi 6*. He then went to London for the BAFTAs, returning to complete the songs for Mani Ratnam's *Ravaana* and hand over the soundtrack of *Blue* to first time director Anthony D'Souza in Chennai. Work is what has

got Rahman to the point where he is India's most recognised name in entertainment, which is why he also barely had time to give his measurements for a bandgalla to friend and long time manager Noell James for his red carpet attire. Ultimately, he went with Rohit Bal. All interviews, business meetings, and chat shows are scheduled for immediately after the Oscar ceremony. But Rahman is not letting the Oscar nominations for best original score, and songs *O...saya* and *Jai ho* change him. He returns to India on February 27 and flies to Mumbai for a film award function on February 28.



AP